

SESSIONS THREE & FOUR: THE PROVING BELOW

The Qilvayas Symphony

A two-session dungeon module for 4–6 characters of 4th level — the tenth bell, the Undervault, and the examination nobody announced

OVERVIEW

Session Three opens at Vaelindra's table for the conversation she promised, and ends deep inside a dungeon the party believes is a rescue mission. Session Four finishes the dungeon, defeats or outwits its warden, and detonates the twist: the entire commission was staged. The Undervault is the academy's hidden proving ground, the missing survey team is faculty, the monsters were leashed, and the party has just passed the most consequential examination the empire offers — the Proving, a final test administered only to exceptional cohorts, and only ever revealed at its conclusion.

One thing inside the dungeon, however, is not part of the test — a sealed pre-imperial door the staff's own maps omit, cold to the touch in a way one party member's pocket already understands. The Proving is a closed loop; the Cold Door is the campaign leaning in.

Both sessions are designed for five hours. Session Three pacing budget: the tenth bell at Vaelindra's (60 minutes); the summons and briefing (40 minutes); Undervault Level One — U1 to U9, the Cipher Gate among them (95 minutes); Level Two — U10 to U17, including the Registry Wall (85 minutes), ending on the discovery of the Cold Door at U18 (20 minutes, unhurried — it is the cliffhanger). Session Four: recap and the door (30 minutes); finishing Level Two (25 minutes); the Processional and the Gauntlet Walk (35 minutes); the Vault Warden in three phases (75 minutes); the Reveal (45 minutes); aftermath and hooks (50 minutes). The party reaches 4th level at the start of Session Three and 5th at the end of Session Four, when the Proving concludes.

If you are running the keyed dungeon: the twenty-three areas below are the same two sessions at higher resolution, not extra content bolted on, and the budget above already assumes them. Level One's ninety-five minutes covers U1 to U9 including the Cipher Gate at a real puzzle's pace; Level Two's eighty-five covers U10 to U17 with the Registry Wall. If the table is slow, U2, U3, and U8 are the three areas that can be described rather than played without losing anything the module needs. If the table is fast, the wandering table and the third solution to the Registry Wall will absorb an hour between them.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (DM ONLY)

The Proving is real academy tradition (see the sourcebook, The Proving, DM Only). The cohort's performance in the field — and something in how their exercise report read — moved the faculty to invoke it. The cover story is a silent survey team in the decommissioned Undervault; the truth is a

controlled environment: constructs on training protocols, beasts on warded collars, faculty observing from concealed galleries, and mercy sigils throughout that translocate anyone reduced to 0 hit points to the infirmary. Nobody can die in the Proving. The faculty have run it eleven times in the current chancellor's tenure and are quietly proud of the safety record.

Except: the Undervault's deepest wall touches the Undercourt — the pre-imperial stratum beneath Aenodira (see the sourcebook, Geography and Locations) — and one sealed black-stone door on Level Two predates the academy, the empire, and every map the staff possess. The mercy wards end ten feet from it; the wards will not anchor in that stone, a fact the enchanters papered over decades ago rather than explain. Hairline survey marks near its hinge, three years old, are in Empress Nyreeza's personal cipher — though nobody at the table can know that yet. Nothing attacks the party there. Nothing needs to. The door is doing its work by existing.

Run the whole module playing it absolutely straight. The dungeon is real, the danger reads as real, and the DM's job is to be genuinely trying to make the party believe. If the players smell the staging early — the punch-pulling constructs, the suspiciously curriculum-shaped challenges — do not panic and do not confirm: the faculty's real question simply becomes whether the cohort finishes the job anyway, and that is a better test than the one they planned. Grace under deception is the Proving's true subject.

PART ONE — SESSION THREE

SCENE 1: THE TENTH BELL

The tea is already poured when you arrive, which means she watched you cross the square. The ledger is closed this morning. Vaelindra of the Still Waters looks like she has slept well and thought hard, in that order, and she waits until the door is latched before she speaks. "Sit. I have decided what you can carry, and it is more than I expected and less than you want."

What she gives them, in her own order and at her own pace:

The acceleration. Fragmentary visions — the storm, the wrong fire, the shape behind the sky — have reached her for fifty years, from strangers who never met. But the arrivals changed: "Three years ago, almost to the season, they quickened. I mark my ledger by the bells. I do not believe in

coincidence; I believe in causes.” She does not say what else happened three years ago. If a player makes the connection to the Empress’s disappearance aloud, she goes very still, then nods once, slowly, and moves on — confirmation without a word.

The counsel. Do not go to the Office of Omens; do not let the Office come to them. Finish the academy, graduate, become unremarkable: “Normalcy is armor. Wear it while it fits.” Report to her anything strange — and anything cold.

The medallion. Keep it, and keep it moving. “Things like this are quieter in the pockets of people who keep their word. I do not fully know why. I have fifty years of ledger that says it is so.” (This is the campaign’s mechanism whispering; confirm nothing.)

The city beneath. Delivered last, almost as an afterthought, and worth its weight: “Everything in Aenodira stands on something older. The academy most of all — scholars always build on bones. If your school ever sends you down — and it sends its best down, eventually; it always has — pay attention to what is cold.” She will not elaborate. She is not omniscient; she has simply spent fifty years listening to people who went under the city and came back changed, or did not come back.

What she withholds: everything touching the founding, Threnvos, and the content of her final meeting with Nyreeza. If pressed on the Empress directly: “That lady trusted me with things I will spend on the day they are needed and not one day sooner. You are not asking a small thing. You are asking whether I keep faith. Watch and find out.” Milestone: the party reaches 4th level when this scene closes.

SCENE 2: THE SUMMONS

The summons finds them before noon — an academy runner, slightly out of breath, with the seal of the Chancellery: report to Professor Corvin Dail, Master of Trials, immediately. In Dail’s spare office (racked practice weapons, one chair, no comforts), the briefing is crisp:

Five days ago, a three-person academy survey team descended into the Undervault — the sealed pre-imperial vault complex beneath the academy’s oldest wing — to catalogue Vault Nine for the Law Commission’s records inventory. They have not reported since. The Undervault’s old wards defeat scrying.

The party’s commission: descend, locate the team, render aid, and recover the Lector’s Seal — the archival master-key the team carried, without which half the academy’s deep records are inaccessible. Bring everyone home.

Why them and not faculty: “Because you are the cohort that cleared Redwatch, and because every instructor who can fight is examining first-years this week. Consider it a compliment with teeth.”

The compensation, delivered with a perfectly straight face: “Succeed, and the chancellery will consider your final examinations satisfied.” (Every word of the briefing is technically true. This line is the module’s best joke, and nobody will get it for two sessions.)

Give them a preparation beat — equipment requisitions are approved with suspicious speed — and one detail for later: Dail’s provided map of Levels One and Two is precise, professional, and has one drafting smudge on the eastern edge of Level Two, as though something was erased or never surveyed. A DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check on the map notices it now; otherwise it lands in retrospect.

SCENE 3: LEVEL ONE — THE ARCHIVE HALLS

The Undervault opens off a stair behind three locks, and the air changes on the fourth step — dry, cold, papery, old. Below, corridors run straight and square under barrel vaults, lined with iron shelf-cages of ledgers nobody has touched in a century. Your lanterns push the dark back exactly as far as lantern-light should, and no further. Somewhere below, metal scrapes on stone — once, deliberately, like something finishing a step.

Run Level One as a classic corridor-and-chamber crawl — encourage a player to map. This level teaches the dungeon’s vocabulary and stages the missing-team fiction:

The survey camp. Bedrolls, a cold lamp, a half-written catalogue page ending mid-line, and a scatter of dropped instruments — staged with real skill. DC 13 Investigation: the scene reads genuinely wrong-but-recent. DC 16: the lamp’s oil level and the dust say the camp is older than five days — the first loose thread, if anyone pulls it.

The cipher gate. A bronze door bearing a rotating-ring lock inscribed in Old Imperial legal shorthand — a House of the Seal education solves it outright (automatic for Seal-primary characters; DC 13 Intelligence (History) otherwise; a thief’s tools attempt at DC 15 works but triggers a shrieking alarm glyph that costs surprise on this level). The lock’s phrasing is, verbatim, a first-year contracts exercise. File that.

Encounter — Drill Automatons. Two Drill Automatons (three for a party of five, four for six) patrol the halls — man-shaped training constructs of the old imperial pattern, animated and hostile. They fight competently and lose convincingly. Their tell, for observant players (DC 13 Wisdom (Insight) during combat): they check their swings against downed or badly wounded targets. They never deliver a finishing blow. The DM should play this completely deadpan.

The healing font. A working restorative font in a side chapel (1d4 + 1 charges of cure wounds at 1st level, self-administered) — a gift with a question mark: fonts this old should not still be charged. (It was recharged last week.)

SCENE 4: LEVEL TWO — THE MENAGERIE STACKS

The second level is wetter and older — the shelving gives way to crate-vaults and barred alcoves, and the dark has a smell now: animal, musk and straw, wrong for a place sealed for lifetimes. Something pads pace-for-pace with you behind the eastern shelves, claws clicking a patient rhythm on stone. It is not trying very hard to be quiet.

Level Two escalates the fiction and hides the module’s two most important discoveries:

Encounter — Vault Hounds. Three Vault Hounds (four for five characters, five for six) — lean, gray, wolf-sized beasts with bronze collars — hunt the party through the stacks in coordinated pack rushes. The collars are the point: DC 12 Intelligence (Arcana) in combat identifies binding runes; the collars can be targeted (AC 15, 10 hp) or removed from a restrained hound (DC 13 Dexterity check). A hound freed of its collar disengages immediately, shakes itself like a wet dog,

and becomes entirely docile — it was compelled, not cruel. Freed hounds follow the party amiably. (They are the academy kennels' wardbeasts, and they know perfectly well the party is not prey; the collars made them perform otherwise.)

"Merla." Huddled in a locked records cage: a terrified junior archivist, the survey team's "sole remaining member" — dehydrated, tearful, and desperate to be escorted out immediately, abandoning the mission and the other two "survivors." She is Instructor Liria Fenn of the House of the Craft (rhetoric and stagecraft), in light disguise and giving the performance of her career. Her function is to test the party's triage: Do they split the group? Abandon the objective? How do they treat a helpless stranger who is costing them time? She resists direct magical detection with a warded amulet (the faculty are not amateurs); a DC 18 Wisdom (Insight) may notice her terror never quite reaches her breathing. If unmasked early, she breaks character with remarkable good humor — see the Reveal for guidance — and the Proving continues around her.

The Custodian. A room-filling translucent ooze methodically scouring a spill of ancient preservative from the flagstones. The Custodian Ooze is real, ancient, and harmless unless attacked or interfered with — it is, functionally, the Undervault's janitor, and it has been down here longer than the academy has stood above. It ignores creatures and consumes messes. Parties who watch it work learn something true; parties who attack everything learn something too, and the faculty note both.

Bartleby. A treasure chest sits implausibly alone in a cleared alcove, lit almost theatrically. It is a mimic — a real one, old and fat and semi-tame, kept and fed by generations of Undervault staff, and it is the single least subtle test in the Proving: the faculty want to know who checks. Poke it, feed it, or greet it and it bumbles amiably and returns to being furniture; grab the "gold" and it grapples the offender with the enthusiasm of a creature that thinks wrestling is a love language. It stops on a word from anyone it has tasted food from. Its name is Bartleby. The staff will deny this, and then Dail will absolutely say it during the Reveal.

THE COLD DOOR — ENDING SESSION THREE

Behind the collapsed shelving in the eastern stacks — the stretch the hounds would not enter, where the map goes smudged — the brickwork of the vault simply stops, and older stone begins: black, roughly hewn, fitted without mortar, the same stone as the Founder's Wall a mile above. Set into it is a door. No handle. No keyhole. No seam wide enough for a knife. The iron of its face is furrowed with frost in a corridor where nothing else is even damp, and the cold reaches you a full pace before your hand — the exact cold, one of you realizes, that rides in a certain pocket, that has ridden there since Redwatch. Along the hinge-line, faint as scratches on ice: rows of tiny, deliberate marks. Someone stood exactly here, in the cold, and wrote something — carefully, and not long ago.

Let them investigate: the marks are a cipher no one can read tonight (a charcoal rubbing is the obvious move — let them think of it); the door does not open by any means available at this tier; the frost re-forms as they watch. Whoever carries Dren's medallion feels it grow noticeably colder within ten feet of the door — the module's single loudest clue, delivered in complete silence. End the session here, at the door, in the cold. (**DM note:** the mercy wards end ten feet behind the party. Nothing here will hurt them. Do not tell them that.)

PART TWO — SESSION FOUR

SCENE 5: THE DOOR, BY MORNING LOGIC

Open with the party still below (the Undervault has no morning) and let them resolve the door on their own terms: rubbing taken, position marked on their map — correcting the official map's smudge — theories argued. Characters proposing to force it find good reasons to fail; the module's honest answer is not yet. When they disengage and press on, the hounds (if any were freed) visibly relax the moment the door is out of sight.

SCENE 6: LEVEL THREE — THE VAULT PROPER

The final stair descends into engineered dark: a processional corridor of paired columns, and at its end, doors of green-black bronze standing twelve feet tall, relief-carved with the wolf-standard of an empire two centuries younger than it is now. From behind them, a voice — vast, level, neither kind nor unkind — speaks a challenge that has waited a very long time to be answered: "PRESENT THE WARRANT OF ACCESS. UNWARRANTED ENTRY IS DEFENDED."

The corridor itself is the third house's trial (the Seal had the cipher gate, the Craft has had a level of machines and bindings; the Sword gets its own): the Gauntlet Walk, a forty-foot stretch of alternating pressure plates and arrow-loops built for formation drill. A party that advances in disciplined formation — shields forward, called steps; any Sword-primary character can direct it (grant the group advantage) — crosses with a group DC 12 Dexterity save (2d6 piercing on failure, half on success, nonlethal by ward though it does not feel that way). A disorganized rush faces DC 14 and disadvantage. The corridor is, transparently in hindsight, a drill yard.

Beyond the doors: Vault Nine, a domed rotunda, empty shelving radiating from a central plinth where the Lector's Seal rests in a shaft of pale wardlight — and the Vault Warden between them and it: a nine-foot construct of blackened bronze in the pattern of the old imperial honor guard, halberd grounded, waiting. It repeats its demand once. Then it defends.

THREE WAYS PAST THE WARDEN

The Warrant. A genuine Warrant of Access exists, folded inside the staged survey camp's half-written catalogue (Level One) — findable there, or its existence deducible from the Warden's own phrasing (the faculty consider retrieving it the perfect score). Presented, the Warden grounds its halberd, steps aside, and bows. Full marks.

The Phrase. The plinth inscriptions (readable during combat with a DC 15 Intelligence (History) check as an action, or before it by a party that scouts) include the archivists' old stand-down formula in Old Imperial. Spoken loudly and correctly, it ends the fight at once.

The Yield. The Warden fights to half its hit points, then — per a protocol no intruder would expect — grounds its weapon, kneels, and speaks: “SUFFICIENT.” (Its instructions were always to test, not to kill; it has been testing people since before the fracture.)

SCALING THE WARDEN

Baseline (4 characters): the Vault Warden alone. Five characters: one Drill Automaton enters from an alcove on round 2. Six characters: two automatons from round 1, and the Warden’s Bulwark trait is active until both automatons fall. Add exactly that many and no more — a second automaton at five characters crosses the encounter-multiplier boundary and nearly doubles the adjusted difficulty rather than nudging it, which is how a Proving that cannot kill anyone starts feeling like one that wants to. The encounter is deliberately hot for the tier — that is what the yield protocol, the warrant, the phrase, and (unknown to the players) the mercy wards are for. Let it feel dangerous. It is allowed to be, because it cannot actually be.

SCENE 7: THE REVEAL

The Seal is barely in your hands when the sound begins — stone grinding on stone, but vast, orchestral, everywhere at once. The rotunda’s far wall splits along seams you would have sworn were solid, and folds outward, and beyond it: light. Tiered galleries. Chairs. People. The entire senior faculty of the Imperial Academy of the Lupine Throne, rising to their feet — and applauding. Professor Dail stands at the rail with his arms crossed, wearing the first unguarded expression you have ever seen on him. Beside him, the “missing” survey team, in perfect health, clapping hardest of all. And stepping down toward you, arms spread, commencement-voice already unfurling: the Chancellor of the academy. “Congratulations, graduates. Be at ease — and be proud. You are the twelfth cohort in my tenure to undergo the Proving, and the first to — ” and here the polish cracks, just slightly, into something real — “ — well. We will discuss what you found. Sit. All of you. You have earned every chair in this room.”

Run the Reveal in three movements, and give it the full forty-five minutes:

The mechanics, disclosed. Chancellor Emeth Sorral and Dail lay it out plainly: the Proving’s tradition and secrecy; the training constructs and their checked swings; the collars; the mercy sigils (“no student has ever died in the Proving; several have woken very surprised in the infirmary”); Fenn peeling off Merla’s scarf with a bow (if unmasked early, she leads the applause and cheerfully itemizes exactly when each player’s suspicion showed); Dail scolding Bartleby by name if anyone mentions the chest. Dail then delivers his critique — personalized to the table’s actual choices, praising by noting the absence of error, and treating a bloodless run (freed hounds, presented warrant, spoken phrase) as the highest possible marks.

The feelings, honored. Then let the party react — and let it be complicated. They were deceived, skillfully, by an institution they trust, for reasons that institution believes justify the method, and they are simultaneously being celebrated. Some characters will be elated; some will be furious; the most interesting tables will be both at once. Sorral does not apologize and does not gloat: “You are owed the truth of why. An examination you know is an

examination measures your preparation. Only a test you believe is real measures what you are. We needed to know what you are. Now we do — and so, I think, do you.” (**DM note:** this is the campaign’s thematic rhyme — benevolent deception inside an empire founded on a lie — and it must never be lampshaded. If a player connects it, even half-formed, give it silence and let it ring.)

The door, deflected. When — not if — the party raises the Cold Door, Dail waves it off with genuine unconcern: “Older than our lease. It was sealed before your grandparents; it stays sealed; it is not on the syllabus.” Sorral is another matter. The commencement-polish stops entirely. He asks exactly one question — “You say there were marks. Recent marks?” — listens to the answer without moving, thanks them with complete formality, and changes the subject with the smoothness of a man closing a ledger. He does not ask a second question. That is the tell. (Within days, the party can notice masons re-sealing the eastern stacks. The rubbing in their possession is now the only copy of whatever was written there.)

SCENE 8: AFTERMATH

The Proving concluded, events move quickly, and each beat below deserves table time in the closing hour:

Commencement, early. The Proven cohort graduates in a small, strangely moving ceremony within the week — four weeks early, by the Chancellor’s privilege. Their sealed records now carry a designation almost nobody can read and certain offices in Highcourt absolutely can.

The company, chartered. The chancellery countersigns their mercenary charter as its graduation gift — but the countersignature is the smaller half of it, and a Seal-house character will say so. Under Book Three certification is always two things: the mark, and a matching entry in the certifying body’s own register. An academy chancellery is not one of the three registers, so the company is not truly chartered until the Capital Merchants’ Concord enters it in the Crown-guild books — a fee, a queue, a bored clerk, and one line of copperplate that is now the only thing standing between the company and a magistrate’s challenge. Play it in ten minutes as Optional Content if the table has appetite; it costs nothing and it is the rule the rest of the campaign runs on. With that entry made, the company they named in Session Zero is a legal entity of the empire — and grants a founding purse of 300 gp. If the party thinks to use the Lector’s Seal’s recovery as their first “completed contract” on the company’s ledger, allow it with delight; Sorral formally gifts them the Seal’s worn original housing as their company’s sealing-stamp, which means the party’s promises will henceforth literally be closed under a seal recovered from beneath the city. Say none of this aloud.

The rubbing, read — partly. Brought to Archivist Vell, the cipher stops him mid-motion, ledger half-closed. He identifies the hand in one sentence and will not be drawn further in the academy’s walls: “That is the Empress’s personal shorthand. I archived nine years of her academy correspondence. You will not repeat that in this building, and you will tell me — elsewhere — exactly where you found it.” Translation of the fragment itself is a future thread: partial, tantalizing, and the natural bridge to the Nyreeza trail. (Suggested partial reading, when the time comes: a survey notation — a depth, a bearing, and the single legible phrase “colder past the second seal.”)

Vaelindra, told. If the party reports to Coppergate — and after her tenth-bell counsel, they should think of it — she listens to the whole account without interrupting, and

answers with the module's closing line. See the epigraph. What she now knows, and they do not: Nyreeza went beneath the city through the academy at least once — which means the Empress's trail and the party's school have been the same building all along.

Milestone. The party reaches 5th level. The first arc of the campaign — students, vision, Seeress, Proving — is complete. They are graduates, chartered, marked by Highcourt, holding a dead man's cold medallion and a dead-or-worse Empress's cipher. The campaign proper is now open in every direction.

THE UNDERVAULT, KEYED

The scenes above are how the two sessions run. This is the dungeon they run in. Twenty-three areas across three levels, drawn so a DM can sketch the map in four minutes on grid paper and hand it to whoever volunteered to be the party's cartographer.

Drawing it. Level One is a rectangle, roughly 200 by 120 feet, cut into a grid of barrel-vaulted corridors ten feet wide with shelf-cages between them — think city blocks, not caves. Level Two is the same footprint gone wrong: the eastern third has subsided, so its corridors bend and its floors slope perhaps five degrees toward the east wall, which is where the black stone begins. Level Three is a single processional axis, ninety feet of columned corridor running dead straight to a domed rotunda sixty feet across. Everything descends by one broad stair at the western end, which is the only way in and, until the Reveal, the only way out.

Light. Nothing down here is lit. This matters more than any trap in the module: the Undervault's whole atmosphere is lantern-light pushing dark back exactly as far as lantern-light should and no further, and a party that solves the light problem cleverly has genuinely earned something. The faculty are watching from galleries in total darkness through observation slits that read as ventilation.

LEVEL ONE — THE ARCHIVE HALLS

U1. The Stair Head. Three locks on the door above, all of them opened for the party. The air changes on the fourth step: dry, cold, papery. A brass plate reads DEPOSIT OF THE ELEVENTH RECORD, LEVELS I TO III, and someone has scratched a tally of eleven marks beside it. The tally is the Proving's count and nobody will explain it for two sessions.

U2. The Reading Floor. A forty-foot hall of stone desks under a barrel vault, every desk with a candle-socket and none with a candle. Dust undisturbed except for one desk near the middle, which has been used within the month. Nothing here. That is the point of it: it teaches the party what undisturbed looks like, so U4 will read wrong.

U3. The Shelf-Cages (north run). Iron cages of ledgers, floor to vault, aisles between. Difficult terrain if a fight happens here, and total cover in inconvenient places. A DC 12 Intelligence (Investigation) among the ledgers turns up a Third Legion muster roll from sixty years ago listing the Silvasse dead — which is not a clue, and is the kind of thing a party will remember for the rest of the campaign anyway.

U4. The Survey Camp. Three bedrolls, a cold lamp, a half-written catalogue page ending mid-line, and dropped instruments. Staged with real skill. DC 13 Investigation: genuinely wrong-but-recent. DC 16: the lamp's oil level and

the dust say the camp is older than five days. The Warrant of Access is folded inside the catalogue page (see Handouts) and a party who searches properly finds it now and does not understand it for two hours.

U5. The Cipher Gate. A bronze door across the central corridor, with a rotating-ring lock inscribed in Old Imperial legal shorthand. See The Cipher Gate, below — this is the module's first real puzzle and it has four solutions.

U6. The Font Chapel. A side chapel with a working restorative font: 1d4 + 1 charges of cure wounds at 1st level, self-administered. Fonts this old should not still be charged, and a party who says so out loud is doing exactly what the faculty hoped. (It was recharged last week.) Above the basin, a worn relief of the Watch at the Threshold.

U7. The Long Gallery. Where the Drill Automatons patrol. Sixty feet of straight corridor with shelf-cages at both ends — deliberately built to be fought in, with a clean approach and no cover in the middle, because it is a drill hall pretending to be an archive.

U8. The Clerk's Room. A dead-end office with a desk, a chair, and two hundred years of unfiled requisitions. The room is a joke that pays off later: every requisition is for lamp oil, and the last one is dated last month.

U9. The Descent. The stair to Level Two, behind a grille that is unlocked. The grille's hinges have been oiled. Recently.

LEVEL TWO — THE MENAGERIE STACKS

U10. The Sloping Hall. The first sign the level is wrong: the floor tilts east, gently, and every dropped object rolls. Wetter air, and the animal smell — musk and straw, in a place sealed for lifetimes.

U11. The Crate Vaults. Barred alcoves and crate-stacks, the Vault Hounds' hunting ground. Broken sightlines, climbable stacks (DC 10 Athletics), and three chokepoints a clever party can use. The hounds know this room; the party does not.

U12. The Records Cage. Where Merla is found, locked in. The lock is old, real, and openable from outside with thieves' tools at DC 12 or by the key hanging forty feet away in U14 — which is a small, mean little test of whether anyone looks before breaking.

U13. The Custodian's Reach. A wide low chamber with a spill of ancient preservative across the flagstones, and the Custodian Ooze methodically scouring it. It ignores creatures and consumes messes. Crossing the room while it works is entirely safe and feels like the least safe thing in the module.

U14. The Kennel Office. Collar-racks, feed bins, a workbench, and the cage key on a nail. Also a leather-bound kennel log in a neat modern hand, current to last week, recording each hound by name. One of the names is Bartleby, which is not a dog.

U15. Bartleby's Alcove. A cleared alcove, theatrically lit by a shaft from a ventilation slit that is not a ventilation slit, containing one chest. See the scene text. Bartleby is old, fat, semi-tame, and the least subtle test in the Proving.

U16. The Registry Wall. The module's second puzzle. See below.

U17. The Eastern Stacks. Collapsed shelving, and the stretch the hounds will not enter. The floor's tilt is at its worst here and the cold begins about fifteen feet out.

U18. The Cold Door. Where Session Three ends. Black stone, fitted without mortar, no handle, no keyhole, no seam. Frost on the iron in a corridor where nothing else is damp. The hinge-line marks are here (see Handouts). The mercy wards end ten feet behind the party and nothing here will hurt them, and the DM must not say so.

LEVEL THREE — THE VAULT PROPER

U19. The Processional. Paired columns, ninety feet, dead straight, built to be walked down by people who knew they were being watched. Sound carries here perfectly, which is a gift to a party who wants to talk to what is at the end of it.

U20. The Gauntlet Walk. Forty feet of alternating pressure plates and arrow-loops. Full trap block below.

U21. The Bronze Doors. Twelve feet tall, green-black, relief-carved with a wolf-standard two centuries older than it should be. The Warden's challenge comes from behind them. The doors are not locked; they have never needed to be.

U22. Vault Nine. A domed rotunda sixty feet across, empty shelving radiating from a central plinth, and the Lector's Seal in a shaft of pale wardlight. The Warden stands between. The plinth carries the inscriptions that hold the stand-down phrase.

U23. The Gallery Wall. The rotunda's far wall, which is not a wall. It splits along seams that looked solid and folds outward into tiered galleries holding the entire senior faculty. Until it opens, a DC 20 Perception notices the seams — and a party that spots them before the Reveal has beaten the module, which the faculty will find delightful.

PUZZLES

Both puzzles below have several genuine solutions, and none of them is the intended one. This is stated here because it is easy for a DM to develop a favorite mid-session and start steering; do not. A party that gets through by a route this book did not think of has solved it correctly by definition.

THE CIPHER GATE (U5)

The door is bronze, taller than a man, and set into it at chest height is a lock of five concentric rings, each ring bearing the same twenty-two marks. Above them, incised in the metal and worn shallow by two centuries of fingers tracing it, one line of Old Imperial legal shorthand. Below the rings, a shallow brass tray, empty, the size of a hand.

The line reads, in translation: WHAT IS PROMISED, WHERE IT IS WRITTEN, WHO STOOD BY, WHAT IT COST, WHEN IT WAS DONE. Five rings; five clauses; the marks are the shorthand for the five parts of a valid imperial covenant. Set each ring to its clause's mark and the door opens.

Solution one — the education. A House of the Seal character recognizes the phrasing instantly, because it is verbatim a first-year contracts exercise. Automatic for a

Seal-primary character; the joke is that they had to memorize it for a grade.

Solution two — the scholarship. DC 13 Intelligence (History) reconstructs the five-clause form from any legal education, imperial or otherwise. A Tarnovari or Orlathine character makes this at DC 15, because their own oath-forms are different and they have to translate first.

Solution three — the tray. The brass tray takes a seal. Any genuine imperial seal pressed into it while the rings are wrong opens the door anyway, on the reasoning that a person carrying a seal is a person entitled to be here. The party has no seal yet. They will have one at the end of Session Four, and a DM who lets them realize this in retrospect has given them a free gift.

Solution four — the craft. Thieves' tools at DC 15 defeats the lock outright. It also triggers a shrieking alarm glyph (see Traps) that costs the party surprise on this level for the next hour. This is not a failure state and should never be run as one — it is a legitimate answer with a price, and a party who takes it knowingly has made a choice, not a mistake.

DM Only: the fifth solution is asking. If the party goes back up and asks Professor Dail what the shorthand means, he will tell them, because his instructions are to answer any question they actually think to ask. Nobody has ever gone back up. If this table does, give it to them warmly and note it: the faculty will regard it as the single most impressive thing the cohort did.

THE REGISTRY WALL (U16)

The wall at the end of the eastern stacks is not shelving. It is a registry: nine hundred small square drawers, nine high and a hundred wide, each with a brass card-holder and a number, and every card is blank. In the middle of the wall, at the height of your chest, one drawer stands a finger's width open. Behind you, the floor tilts east, and somewhere in the dark something with claws is not trying very hard to be quiet.

The open drawer holds a single iron key, too large for any lock on this level, and a card that is not blank. It reads, in a modern hand: SEE ALSO. Nothing else.

The wall is a finding aid for a collection that was moved, and the puzzle is what a registry with nine hundred blank cards is for. The answer: the cards were never written. The drawers themselves are the index — their positions encode a shelf-mark, and the one standing open gives the party a coordinate. Read as row-and-column, the open drawer's position points to a location: the eastern stacks, fifteen feet in, at floor level. That is U18. The registry is telling them where the Cold Door is.

Solution one — count it. Anybody who counts the drawer's position and thinks of it as a map coordinate gets it. DC 13 Intelligence (Investigation), and a character with a cartographer's or navigator's background does it without a roll.

Solution two — the key. The key fits nothing on Level Two. It fits the grille at U9, which is already unlocked, and a party who tries it there learns that this key is older than that grille by a century — which tells them the registry predates the academy's occupation, which is the actual finding.

Solution three — pull them all. Nine hundred drawers, most empty, some holding a century of dust and four holding something. It takes an hour of game time and it works. Reward it: the four occupied drawers hold a dried flower, a child's tooth, forty Zhuven in obsolete coin, and a lock of white hair tied with a black thread. None of them means anything. All of them will haunt the players, and the DM should refuse to explain any of it, forever.

Solution four — ask the hounds. A freed Vault Hound will not go east past the registry. A party that notices the hound's line and treats it as information rather than cowardice has been told exactly where the wrong thing is, by a dog, which is the most Zhuvedian solution available.

DM Only: the SEE ALSO card is in Empress Nyreeza's hand. It matches the hinge-line marks at U18 and it is three years old. Do not point at it. A party that keeps the card and later compares it to anything of hers has found her, and they will have found her by tidying up after a puzzle.

TRAPS

The Gauntlet Walk (U20). Mechanical trap, forty feet of corridor.

Trigger: weight on any plate. The plates are obvious — DC 10 Perception spots the seams, and the arrow-loops are not concealed at all. This trap is not hiding.

Effect: the corridor discharges as a group. A party advancing in disciplined formation (shields forward, called steps; any Sword-primary character can direct it, granting the group advantage) makes a group DC 12 Dexterity saving throw. A disorganized rush is DC 14 with disadvantage. On a failure: 2d6 piercing damage. On a success: half.

Duration: the corridor discharges once per creature crossing, then resets over one minute.

Countermeasures: the plates can be jammed with anything rigid (DC 13 Dexterity with thieves' tools, one plate per attempt, four plates in the run). The arrow-loops can be blocked from the near side with a shield or a bedroll, two loops per action. Crossing the whole run prone at half speed avoids the loops entirely and takes four rounds, which is fine and which nobody ever thinks of.

What it actually is: a drill yard. In hindsight the whole thing is a formation exercise, the damage is nonlethal by ward though it does not feel it, and the arrow-loops are firing blunts. Do not tell them.

The Shrieking Glyph (U5). Magical trap on the Cipher Gate, triggered only by forced entry.

Trigger: the lock is opened by any means other than setting the rings or pressing a seal into the tray.

Effect: a rising tone audible throughout Level One and faintly on Level Two, lasting one minute. No damage. For the next hour, the party cannot surprise anything on Level One and everything on Level One knows roughly where they are.

Detect and disarm: DC 15 Intelligence (Arcana) to spot before triggering; DC 15 thieves' tools or dispel magic to disarm. A character who spots it and chooses to trigger it anyway, having weighed the cost, should be told plainly that this is a legitimate call.

The Subsidence (U10 through U17). Environmental hazard, the whole eastern third of Level Two.

Effect: the floor tilts about five degrees east. Any creature knocked prone slides 10 feet east before stopping. Any dropped object rolls east until it hits something. A creature running east makes a DC 10 Dexterity save or overruns by 10 feet.

Why it is here: so that the dungeon has a direction, and the direction is toward the Cold Door. Every accident in this level moves the party toward the thing the module is about. Nobody will notice, and it will work anyway.

THE VAULT WARDEN, IN THREE PHASES

The Warden is the module's set piece and it should not be run as one long fight. It runs in three phases with a decision at each transition, and the party's route through those decisions is what the faculty are actually grading.

Phase One — The Challenge (rounds 0 to 1). The Warden repeats its demand once, and waits one full round. This is a real round: it will not attack during it, and the party can act freely. The decision at this transition is whether anyone answers. Presenting the Warrant here ends the encounter with full marks and the Warden bowing. Speaking the stand-down phrase ends it here too. Attacking during the waiting round is a legitimate choice and a bad one, and the DM should let it happen without a warning glance.

Phase Two — The Defense (rounds 2 to the halfway mark). The Warden defends. It fights the way a bronze honor guard from two centuries ago fights: positionally, patiently, holding the plinth and never pursuing past the columns. It does not target the downed. The decision at this transition is whether anyone is still trying to solve the room while the fight is happening — the plinth inscriptions are readable during combat with a DC 15 Intelligence (History) check as an action, which costs a turn, in a fight the party thinks might kill them. That trade is the phase's whole content.

Phase Three — The Yield (at half hit points). The Warden grounds its halberd, kneels, and says SUFFICIENT. Its instructions were always to test, not to kill. The decision at this transition is the one the faculty care most about: does the party stop? A party that keeps swinging at a kneeling construct is not penalized mechanically and is watched, in silence, by forty people they cannot see.

Scaling. Baseline (4 characters): the Warden alone. Five characters: one Drill Automaton enters from an alcove on round 2. Six characters: two automatons from round 1, and the Warden's Bulwark trait is active until both automatons fall. Add exactly that many and no more — a second automaton at five characters crosses the encounter-multiplier boundary and nearly doubles the adjusted difficulty rather than nudging it, which is how a Proving that cannot kill anyone starts feeling like one that wants to.

WANDERING THE UNDERVAULT

Roll a d8 once per hour of exploration, or whenever the party is dithering. Half of these are not fights, and three of them are the module quietly telling the truth.

Fenn unmasked early vs. late: Unmasked early, Fenn's post-Proving notes become a standing offer: informal tutoring in reading institutional deception — mechanically, occasional advantage on Insight against official lies, at the cost of Fenn knowing the party's tells. Deceived to the end, she is kinder about it than anyone expects, and more dangerous: she knows exactly which lies each character believed.

The door, disclosed vs. withheld: What the party tells the faculty about the Cold Door shapes Sorral. Full disclosure (marks, cold, the medallion's reaction): he re-seals the wing within days and begins his own quiet inquiry — a potential ally or leak later. Partial disclosure: the re-sealing happens anyway (the observation galleries saw them find it), but Sorral does not know about the rubbing, which stays the party's sole advantage. If anyone shows him the rubbing itself, he goes very still and asks to keep it — do not let the players miss that refusing the Chancellor of the academy is a choice.

STAT BLOCKS

Drill Automaton

Medium construct, unaligned

Armor Class: 15 (natural armor)

Hit Points: 27 (5d8 + 5)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14 (+2)	10 (+0)	12 (+1)	3 (-4)	8 (-1)	1 (-5)

Damage Immunities: poison, psychic

Condition Immunities: charmed, exhaustion, frightened, poisoned

Senses: darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 9

Languages: understands Old Imperial commands

Challenge: 1 (200 XP)

Training Protocol. The automaton cannot reduce a creature below 1 hit point unless that creature has attacked it since the start of its last turn; against downed or unconscious creatures it visibly checks its swing and re-targets. A creature that observes this in combat may make a DC 13 Wisdom (Insight) check to register that the behavior is deliberate.

Antique Joints. If the automaton takes a critical hit, its speed is halved until the end of its next turn as servos grind.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The automaton makes two padded-mace attacks.

Padded Mace. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 6 (1d8 + 2) bludgeoning damage.

Vault Hound

Medium beast, unaligned (compelled)

Armor Class: 13 (natural armor)

Hit Points: 26 (4d8 + 8)

Speed: 40 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
15 (+2)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	4 (-3)	12 (+1)	6 (-2)

Skills: Perception +3, Stealth +4

Senses: darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 13

Languages: —

Challenge: 1 (200 XP)

Pack Tactics. The hound has advantage on attack rolls against a creature if at least one of the hound's allies is within 5 feet of the creature and the ally isn't incapacitated.

Binding Collar. A bronze collar (AC 15, 10 hp, immune to poison and psychic damage) compels the hound's aggression. If the collar is destroyed, or removed from a restrained hound with a successful DC 13 Dexterity check, the hound immediately ends all hostility, becomes docile, and thereafter treats its liberators as pack. A DC 12 Intelligence (Arcana) check identifies the collar's runes as compulsion binding.

ACTIONS

Bite. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 7 (2d4 + 2) piercing damage, and if the target is a creature it must succeed on a DC 12 Strength saving throw or be knocked prone.

Custodian Ooze

Large ooze, unaligned

Armor Class: 6

Hit Points: 50 (6d10 + 17)

Speed: 15 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14 (+2)	3 (-4)	16 (+3)	1 (-5)	6 (-2)	1 (-5)

Damage Immunities: acid, slashing (splits it into two smaller custodians of half remaining hit points each, which continue cleaning)

Condition Immunities: blinded, charmed, deafened, exhaustion, frightened, prone

Senses: blindsight 60 ft. (blind beyond this radius), passive Perception 8

Languages: —

Challenge: 2 (450 XP)

Sanitation Directive. The Custodian does not attack creatures unless attacked first or physically obstructed while consuming a mess. It pursues spills, decay, and debris with single-minded diligence, including any carried open food or unstopped oil a creature is foolish enough to hold near it.

Transparent. Even when in plain sight, a creature that hasn't witnessed the Custodian move must succeed on a DC 14 Wisdom (Perception) check to notice it.

ACTIONS

Dissolving Pseudopod. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. Hit: 10 (3d6) acid damage, and nonmagical leather or cloth worn by the target is stained pristinely clean.

Bartleby (Elder Mimic)

Medium monstrosity (shapechanger), neutral (food-motivated)

Armor Class: 12 (natural armor)

Hit Points: 58 (9d8 + 18)

Speed: 15 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
17 (+3)	12 (+1)	15 (+2)	7 (-2)	13 (+1)	8 (-1)

Skills: Stealth +5

Damage Immunities: acid

Condition Immunities: prone

Senses: darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 11

Languages: — (recognizes roughly forty words, most of them foods)

Challenge: 2 (450 XP)

Shapechanger. Bartleby can use its action to polymorph into an object or back into its amorphous form. Its statistics are the same in each form. It reverts if it dies, or if offered something demonstrably delicious.

Adhesive (Object Form Only). Bartleby adheres to anything that touches it. A Huge or smaller creature adhered to it is also grappled (escape DC 13).

Semi-Tame. Bartleby releases any grapple and returns to furniture-shape on a stern word from any creature that has ever fed it, or on presentation of food. It has been fed by four generations of Undervault staff and considers grappling a form of enthusiastic greeting.

ACTIONS

Pseudopod. Melee Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 7 (1d8 + 3) bludgeoning damage plus the Adhesive trait.

Bite. Melee Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 7 (1d8 + 3) piercing damage plus 4 (1d8) acid damage.

Vault Warden

Large construct, lawful neutral

Armor Class: 17 (plated bronze)

Hit Points: 90 (12d10 + 24)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
20 (+5)	8 (-1)	15 (+2)	6 (-2)	12 (+1)	5 (-3)

Saving Throws: Con +5, Wis +4

Damage Resistances: bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks

Damage Immunities: poison, psychic

Condition Immunities: charmed, exhaustion, frightened, paralyzed, poisoned

Senses: darkvision 120 ft., passive Perception 14

Languages: Old Imperial, Common

Challenge: 5 (1,800 XP)

Warrant Protocol. The Warden stands down permanently if presented a valid Warrant of Access, or if the archivists' stand-down formula is spoken to it in Old Imperial (discoverable via the plinth inscriptions, DC 15 Intelligence (History), usable as an action).

Yield Protocol. When reduced below half its hit point maximum, the Warden grounds its weapon, kneels, and ends all hostility, announcing "SUFFICIENT." Its purpose has always been to test, not to destroy.

Bulwark (Six-Character Parties Only). While at least one allied Drill Automaton is active, the Warden has a +2 bonus to AC.

Sentinel Stance. When the Warden hits a creature with an opportunity attack, the creature's speed becomes 0 for the rest of the turn.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The Warden makes two halberd attacks.

Halberd. Melee Weapon Attack: +8 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. Hit: 15 (3d6 + 5) slashing damage.

Warding Sweep (Recharge 5-6). The Warden sweeps its halberd in a 15-foot cone. Each creature in the cone must succeed on a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw or take 14 (4d6) bludgeoning damage and be knocked prone; on a success, half damage and the creature is not knocked prone.

REACTIONS

Grounded Guard. When a creature the Warden can see attacks the plinth or the Lector's Seal, the Warden moves up to half its speed toward the attacker without provoking opportunity attacks.

NPC PROFILES

PROFESSOR CORVIN DAIL, MASTER OF TRIALS

Human, 60s, ex-legion drillmaster turned educator, House of the Sword to the bone. Speech pattern: parade-ground cadence, economy of words, praises by noting the absence of error ("Nobody died. Nobody split the group past recovery. Acceptable."). He designed the party's Proving personally and considers it his finest; his critique at the

Reveal is the closest thing to a love letter he is capable of writing. Thread: Dail sat the Proving himself, forty years ago — and has never told anyone what his cohort found, or did not find, in the eastern stacks. If the party ever asks him about the door outside academy walls, over a drink, he goes quiet in a way that is not dismissal.

CHANCELLOR EMETH SORRAL

Half-elf, elegantly old, political to the fingertips and a genuine educator underneath it — the ordering of those two facts is the open question of his character. Speech pattern: commencement polish that drops away entirely when he is surprised, which almost nothing achieves. The Cold Door achieves it. Thread: Sorral knows something about the eastern stacks — at minimum that the wards fail there and that the Empress once requested, and was granted, unaccompanied access to the Undervault “for the records inventory.” Whether he connects those facts, and what he owes to whom regarding them, is deliberately unresolved: he can develop into ally, obstacle, or casualty as the campaign needs.

INSTRUCTOR LIRIA FENN

Human, 40s, House of the Craft — rhetoric, stagecraft, and the propaganda arts — and the academy’s best actress by a distance no one contests. As “Merla” she will cost the party time, tears, and at least one hard argument; as herself she is warm, wickedly funny, and merciless in her post-Proving notes on exactly which lies each character believed and why. Thread: Fenn’s classroom subject is, precisely, how institutions make people believe things — which makes her either the most useful ally the party could recruit for the campaign ahead, or the first person to notice when they start lying.

LOOT AND FOUND

REWARDS — SESSIONS

THREE–FOUR — THE PROVING BELOW

Find	Value / Effect
Graduation grant & the Lector’s Seal	Canon (300 gp; the Seal formalized below)
Undervault staged finds (if searched)	Scroll of mage armor; scroll of comprehend languages — with the module’s best DM note: Nyreeza’s cipher is personal shorthand, not a language, and the scroll explicitly does NOT crack it (let a player discover this; it teaches how deep the Empress buried her trail)
The survey team’s kit	Fine cartographer’s tools (25 gp) — and the faculty let the party keep them, which is its own message
Bartleby’s cheese	Priceless. Do not explain the cheese

REWARDS AND ADVANCEMENT

Coin and goods: the 300 gp founding purse; the Lector’s Seal housing as the company’s official sealing-stamp; free graduate access to the academy’s open collections for life (the restricted stacks remain Vell’s to grant); and Bartleby’s sincere affection, redeemable in the Undervault for morale purposes only. The charcoal rubbing of the Cold Door cipher — now the only copy in existence — is the arc’s true treasure, and should be treated with exactly as much narrative weight as the party gives it. XP for tables using it: roughly 2,300–2,900 across both sessions depending on route and resolutions (award full value for the bloodless solutions; they are the harder path and the better marks). Milestone: 5th level when the Proving concludes and the arc closes.

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“So the school sent you down after all. And you paid attention to what was cold. Good. Now sit, children, and tell me about the door — and I will tell you why the Empress’s hand shakes in that cipher.”